Understand Kamba — User Guide

Understand Kamba translates between English and Kikamba, turns spoken Kikamba into text, and reads Kikamba aloud. It is free and works in any modern browser, on a phone or a computer.

Open it at **https://understand-kamba.vercel.app**

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1. Translate text

1. Choose the direction at the top of the card: **English → Kikamba** or **Kikamba → English**.
2. Type or paste your text in the box (up to 500 characters).
3. Tap **Translate**. The translation appears below.

Tips for better translations:

- Write short, complete sentences. The translator works one sentence at a time.
- Check spelling, especially in Kikamba. Use ĩ and ũ where they belong if you can.
- Simple, everyday wording works better than idioms and slang.

The first translation after a quiet period can take up to half a minute while the server wakes up. After that it takes a few seconds.

2. Speak Kikamba instead of typing

When translating from Kikamba:

- Tap the **microphone**, speak, then tap again to stop. Your words appear in the box, ready to translate.
- Or tap **Upload** to choose a Kikamba audio or video file from your phone or computer.

The first time, your browser asks for permission to use the microphone. Choose **Allow**. If you blocked it by mistake, tap the lock icon next to the web address and turn the microphone back on.

Speak clearly, close to the phone, somewhere quiet. Recordings are deleted from the server as soon as they have been turned into text.

3. Listen to Kikamba

Tap the **play** button next to a Kikamba translation to hear it read aloud. Choose **Woman** or **Man** for the voice.

The voice is generated by a computer, not recorded by a person. It is usually clear, but it can mispronounce some words. If the server is very busy, a backup voice with a Swahili accent reads the text instead, and the player tells you so.

4. Choose a dialect

Use the dialect selector to mark which variety you speak: Machakos, Kitui or Makueni. Today every dialect uses the same translator, so this does not change the result yet. Your choice helps us plan dialect support.

5. Rate, copy, save and share

Under each translation you can:

- **Thumbs up / thumbs down** — tell us whether the translation was good. Ratings, with the sentence and its translation, help us find and fix mistakes.
- **Help fix it** — after a thumbs down, a box shows other possible translations. Tap one (and edit it if needed) or type the correct translation, then **Send correction**. Corrections are checked by a Kamba speaker and used to teach the translator.
- **Copy** — copy the translation to paste elsewhere.
- **Save** — keep it under **Saved translations**. Saved translations stay in this browser only; they are not sent anywhere and disappear if you clear your browser data.
- **Share** — create a picture card of your translation for WhatsApp, Instagram, X or Facebook. Choose **Post 4:5** or **Story 9:16**, then **Share**, **Copy image** or **Download**.

6. Help build a Kamba voice

If you speak Kikamba fluently and are 18 or older, you can record yourself reading short Kikamba sentences. These recordings will be used to build a real Kamba voice and better Kamba speech recognition.

1. Tap **Record your voice** on the home page (or go to https://understand-kamba.vercel.app/contribute).
2. Read how your recordings are used. Choose your dialect; gender and age are optional.
3. Tick the three boxes and continue.
4. For each sentence: tap record, read it naturally, tap stop, listen, then **Submit** — or **Re-record** or **Skip**.

We never ask for your name or contact details. You get an anonymous **Contributor ID**, shown at the bottom of the page. To have your recordings deleted, tap **Ask to delete my recordings**; this opens a request on GitHub with your ID filled in. Keep a note of your ID if you may want this later, because it is stored only in your browser. The Contributor and Data Guide has the details.

7. How good is it?

Understand Kamba uses openly available AI models, and they make mistakes. Kikamba → English is generally more accurate than English → Kikamba. Measurements are summarised in the project documentation and the research paper, both on the project's GitHub page.

Do not rely on it for medical, legal, financial or other important matters without checking with a fluent Kikamba speaker.

8. Privacy at a glance

What	Kept?
Text you translate	Not stored, unless you rate the translation (then the text and translation are kept to improve the service)
Audio you speak or upload to translate	Deleted as soon as it is transcribed
Saved translations	Only in your browser
Voice contributions	Stored privately, used as described on the contribute page, deleted on request

9. Problems?

Problem	What to do
"Couldn't reach the translation server"	Wait a minute and try again; the server may be waking up.
Microphone does nothing	Allow microphone access for the site in your browser settings.
"No speech was recognised"	Record again, louder and closer to the microphone, in Kikamba.
The voice has a Swahili accent	The server was busy and used the backup voice. Try again later.
A translation is wrong	Give it a thumbs down — this is how we find mistakes.

To report a bug or suggest an improvement: https://github.com/lawmaluki/understand-kamba/issues